The Gospel in a Letter

Acts 21–28 · Romans 1–8 · Romans 12:1

The big idea: Paul reached Rome in chains, and the word of God went on unhindered. Romans lays out the gospel: all have sinned, and God justifies sinners by grace through faith alone, counting Christ's righteousness to them. Those he justifies he also makes new and keeps forever.

Before you meet: Read

Romans 3:9–26 | Romans 5:1–11 | Romans 8:1, 28–39

Open (5 minutes)

What do most people you know think it takes to be right with God?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"For all have sinned and fall short of the _____ of God." *(Romans 3:23)*

"Therefore, since we have been _____ by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ." *(Romans 5:1)*

"There is therefore now no _____ for those who are in Christ Jesus." *(Romans 8:1)*

"Present your bodies as a living _____, holy and acceptable to God, which is your spiritual worship." *(Romans 12:1)*

Discuss

1. In your own words, what does it mean to be justified? Why does it matter that it is a verdict and a gift? *Romans 3:23–26; 4:5*

2. If we are saved by grace and not by works, why do good works still matter? *Romans 6:1–4; Ephesians 2:8–10*

3. Which part of Romans 8 gives you the most hope? Why? *Romans 8:1, 28–39*

Memory verse

> *"Therefore, since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ."*
>
> **Romans 5:1**

Pray

Thank God that he justifies the ungodly, and that Christ's righteousness is counted to everyone who trusts him. Confess any way you are trying to earn his favor. Pray by name for someone who seems far from God, and offer yourself to him as a living sacrifice.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 48

The Gospel in a Letter

Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Romans 3:21–26 and 8:31–39 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (Hebrews 1:1–4, 4:14–16, and 10:11–25, and James 2:14–26).

Main points to land

1. All have sinned and fall short of the glory of God; no one is righteous by his own works (Romans 3:10–12, 23).
2. Justification is God's verdict: he pardons sinners and counts Christ's righteousness to them, as a gift received by faith alone (Romans 3:24–26; 4:5; WSC 33).
3. Those God justifies he also makes new and keeps forever, and they offer themselves to him as living sacrifices (Romans 6:4; 8:1, 30, 38–39; 12:1).

Core doctrine to teach

Justification by Faith Alone

CORE DOCTRINE 24 OF 26 · FAITH ALONE

God declares guilty sinners righteous in his sight. He pardons all their sins and counts Christ's perfect righteousness as theirs. He does this only because of what Christ has done, never because of what they have done, and they receive it by faith alone. Good works follow as the fruit of being justified. They are never the reason for it. *Romans 3:23–26; 4:5; 5:1; Galatians 2:16; Ephesians 2:8–9*

Answer key (Observe)

1. glory
2. justified
3. condemnation
4. sacrifice

Questions people will ask

If we are saved by faith alone, can we live however we want?

Paul answers, By no means (Romans 6:1–2). Faith unites us to Christ, and those united to him receive his Spirit and a new life. We are saved by faith alone, but the faith that saves is never alone; it always bears fruit (Ephesians 2:8–10).

Closing prayer

Father, you saved Saul the persecutor and made him your servant. Thank you that you justify the ungodly, not because of anything we have done, but because of Christ who died and rose for us. Give us peace with you, freedom from condemnation, and joy in offering ourselves to you. Save the people we think are beyond reach. Amen.